Google Chrome Documentation

A guide to using the browser on the Surface Web

Technical documentation · British English
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1. Introduction

Google Chrome is a free web browser developed by Google, launched in 2008 and now one of the most widely used in the world. This documentation covers the use of Chrome for browsing the Surface Web, the part of the internet indexed by search engines and open to the public, and describes installation, the interface, security and privacy features, extensions and good practice.

The document is aimed at beginner and intermediate users. Because Chrome is updated frequently (since version 153, in September 2026, Google has released a stable version every two weeks), some menus and option names may differ. If you find a discrepancy, consult the official Chrome Help Centre.

2. Overview

- **Chromium base**: Chrome is built on the open-source Chromium project, which also underpins other browsers such as Edge, Brave and Opera.
- **Engines**: it uses Blink to render pages and V8 to run JavaScript.
- **Multi-process architecture**: tabs, extensions and sites run in separate processes, which improves stability and security.
- **Platforms**: Windows, macOS, Linux, Android, iOS/iPadOS and ChromeOS.

Note: because they share the same technical base, many of the tips in this documentation also apply to other Chromium-based browsers, although menus and account features are specific to Chrome.

3. Installation and Updates

1. Go to the official Google Chrome website (google.com/chrome) using a browser that is already installed.
2. Download the installer for your operating system.
3. Run the installer and follow the on-screen instructions. On Linux, use the .deb or .rpm package; on Android and iOS, install it from the official app store.
4. Optionally, set Chrome as your default browser in the system settings.

Chrome updates itself automatically in the background. To check manually, open the three-dot menu, go to **Help > About Google Chrome** and, if an update is pending, click **Relaunch**.

Note: download the browser only from the official website or official app stores. Fake sites imitating the download page are a common way of distributing malicious software.

4. Interface and Basic Use

- **Tab strip**: holds the open pages; tabs can be dragged, pinned and grouped.
- **Omnibox**: a single field for typing addresses (URLs) and searching the web.
- **Menu (three dots)**: gives access to settings, history, downloads, bookmarks, extensions and tools.

- **Bookmarks bar**: shortcuts to the sites you use most.
- **Side panel**: brings together features such as the reading list and bookmarks without leaving the current page.

Useful browsing features

- **Tab groups**: organise tabs by theme or project, with a name and a colour.
- **Profiles**: separate, for example, personal and professional use, each with its own bookmarks, history and extensions.
- **Bookmarks, history and downloads**: available from the menu or through keyboard shortcuts.

Keyboard shortcuts

Windows / Linux	macOS	Function
Ctrl + T	Cmd + T	Open a new tab
Ctrl + W	Cmd + W	Close the current tab
Ctrl + Shift + T	Cmd + Shift + T	Reopen the last closed tab
Ctrl + L	Cmd + L	Select the address bar
Ctrl + D	Cmd + D	Bookmark the page
Ctrl + F	Cmd + F	Search for text on the page
Ctrl + H	Cmd + Y	Open the history
Ctrl + J	Cmd + Shift + J	Open the downloads
Ctrl + Shift + N	Cmd + Shift + N	Open an Incognito window
Ctrl + Shift + Delete	Cmd + Shift + Delete	Clear browsing data
Shift + Esc	Window menu > Task Manager	Chrome Task Manager
F12	Cmd + Option + I	Developer tools

5. Google Account and Sync

Signing in with a Google Account is optional, but it allows you to sync bookmarks, history, passwords, extensions and settings across devices. You choose which types of data to sync and can protect the synced data with a sync passphrase of your own.

Note: on shared or public computers, avoid signing in with your account. Use Guest mode or an Incognito window and sign out when you have finished.

6. Security

Security settings are found under **Settings > Privacy and security > Security**.

- **Safe Browsing**: warns about dangerous sites, suspicious downloads and harmful extensions. The **Enhanced protection** option provides faster checks but involves sending more information to Google.

- **Sandbox and site isolation**: limit the damage a malicious page can do to the system or to other sites.
- **Secure connections (HTTPS)**: Chrome can warn you or ask for confirmation before opening unencrypted sites.
- **Password Manager**: generates, stores and fills in passwords, and warns you when a password has been exposed in a data breach.
- **Passkeys**: an alternative to passwords, based on authentication by the device itself.
- **Safety Check**: a routine that checks for updates, compromised passwords, extensions and permissions.

Note: no protection replaces user vigilance. Be wary of messages that ask for passwords, verification codes or urgent payments, and always check the site's address.

7. Privacy

- **Incognito window**: when closed, it does not keep that session's history, cookies and form data on the device. It does **not** hide your activity from your internet provider, employer, school or the sites you visit.
- **Third-party cookies**: can be blocked or limited under *Privacy and security* > *Third-party cookies*.
- **Site permissions**: camera, microphone, location and notifications can be allowed or denied per site; review them periodically.
- **Clear browsing data**: removes history, cache, cookies and other data for a period of your choosing.
- **Privacy Guide**: a walkthrough of the main privacy settings.

Important: Chrome does not provide anonymity. Sites, providers and, when you are signed in, your account itself can link activity to you. For anonymous browsing, see the Tor Browser documentation in this series.

8. Extensions

Extensions add features to the browser and are installed from the Chrome Web Store using the **Add to Chrome** button. They currently follow the Manifest V3 technical standard.

- Install few extensions, and only those you genuinely need.
- Check the developer, the reviews, the number of users and the permissions requested.
- Remember that many extensions can read or change the content of the pages you visit.
- Remove unused extensions under *Menu* > *Extensions* > *Manage extensions*.

9. Performance and Advanced Tools

- **Memory Saver**: frees up memory from inactive tabs.
- **Energy Saver**: reduces background activity to conserve battery.

- **Task Manager**: shows the resource use of each tab and extension and lets you end processes.
- **Developer tools (DevTools)**: allow you to inspect elements, analyse the network, debug scripts and test how pages display at different screen sizes.

10. Artificial Intelligence Features

Chrome has been adding AI features, such as Gemini in Chrome and AI Mode in the address bar. Availability depends on region, language, account and version. These features may send prompts or extracts of pages to Google services, so review the relevant settings and avoid sharing sensitive information.

11. Troubleshooting

Problem	What to do
The page does not load	Check your connection, reload (F5) or hard reload (Ctrl + Shift + R) and, if the problem persists, clear the cache.
The browser is slow	Close unused tabs, turn on Memory Saver, disable extensions and check the Task Manager.
Unwanted adverts or pop-ups	Review extensions and notification permissions and run Safety Check.
Update fails	Restart the browser and the computer; if the problem persists, reinstall from the official website.
Page shows old content	Hard reload to bypass the cache.

12. Good Practice

- Keep Chrome and your operating system up to date.
- Use strong, unique passwords, preferably with two-step verification or passkeys.
- Check the site's address and the connection icon before entering any data.
- Download files only from trusted sources and be suspicious of unexpected attachments.
- Review site permissions and extensions regularly.
- Use separate profiles for work and personal use.

13. Conclusion

Chrome is a versatile and widely compatible tool for browsing the Surface Web. Knowing its interface, its security features and its privacy options makes it possible to get more from the browser and to reduce risk. Because it was not designed for anonymity, anyone who needs stronger protection of their identity should combine good practice with tools built specifically for that purpose.